



CHELSEA THRIVE

Balloon Debate

A speaking pack for reasoning outside your own brief.
Classroom example · workplace prompt · sample cards.

Rehearse the conversations that matter

This pack is for managers who want a short activity that forces people to argue a case they did not choose. The classroom lists are an example of the form. If you use this with a team, you write — and own — the workplace version.

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How to use this pack

This activity asks people to think out loud under a constraint: ninety seconds, a brief they did not choose, then a vote. That stretch — arguing from someone else's ground — is useful when a team only ever argues from the position it already occupies.

The pack is split on purpose. You get the rules, a classroom example so you can see the form, a prompt for a version that fits your team, and one sample workplace group. The character list, the tone, who may opt out, and the debrief are yours.

Give people this, not the raw classroom list on its own

- The rules — two ways to play, timing, voting. These travel as they are.
- The classroom example — so you can see mixed types, short notes, and how a card is written. Treat it as a model of structure, not a script for an office.
- The generation prompt — paste it into a model, or write the cards yourself. Constrain it. An open “make a workplace version” prompt produces either beige cards or a brief the room cannot hold.
- The sample workplace group — one worked example of the move from school list to staff session.

Do not run the classroom lists as-is in a workplace. They are here so you can see how a card is written — mixed types, short notes, a claim and an objection. Build a set that fits your team. The prompt below is the brief for that.

What this is for

Not a personality contest. Not a values test of the player. The point is the reasoning: build a short case from thin notes, listen to competing claims, change your mind in public if the argument is better, then talk about how people argued — evidence, principle, consequence, story — not who “deserved” to stay.

That sits close to the work at Chelsea Thrive: the conversations that matter are exactly the ones nobody lets you practise. This is a lighter, shared version of the same idea.

How the game works

Picture a hot-air balloon drifting above the trees. Aboard are a handful of characters. Each player becomes one of them. The balloon is sinking. Words are your wings.

You have about ninety seconds to two minutes to plead — why should this character stay? Speak as they would. A pirate might growl more; a teacher might muse. No props. Just the brief, your wit, and a bit of sparkle. Then you choose who floats and who falls.

Two ways to play

1. The Last One Aloft

Only one can stay by the end. Everyone starts aboard. Each round: speak, then vote who goes overboard. One person leaves each round until a lone survivor is left. Write a name that is not your own. Ties: revote, or let the last person eliminated choose. Longer session — better when you have 45–60 minutes and want the reasoning to compound.

2. One Quick Drop

Someone has to go so the rest can lift. Each person pleads once. One vote. Most votes leave. Tie: a thirty-second word-off or a coin. No single champion — the rest sail on. The person who leaves may give a short farewell in character if they want to. Useful for 20–30 minutes. Run a second group if the room is still warm.

Practical rules that travel to work

- Keep pleas short. Two minutes is a ceiling; ninety seconds is better with adults who will otherwise speechify.
- Secret ballot is safer in a workplace than hands up. Pass scraps to a host.
- Nobody votes for themselves. Nobody is required to take a character they do not want — they draw another, no explanation needed.
- Attack the case, not the colleague. The moment it becomes a remark about the person in the chair, stop the round.
- It is a thinking game, not a battle. Tease and bargain if the room can take it. Do not humiliate.
- Always debrief the reasoning, not the winner. Five minutes of “what changed your mind?” does more than another round.

Classroom example

This is a classroom set: historical figures, fictional characters, and socioeconomic roles so players cannot all argue the same way. A physicist, a pirate, a mother of three and a landowner who shoots at weekends force different claims about usefulness, morality, charm and who the world actually needs.

Read it for structure: eight named cards and a blank ninth. Short notes — clues, not speeches. In a taught classroom you can add one optional harder card. This edition does not include one, and a workplace session should not invent one in that register.

The last card in each group is blank on purpose — an easier figure for a less confident player, or a name from your own sector. Not a colleague, and not this week's headline politician.

Group 1

1. Cleopatra (**Historical**) — Last active ruler of the Ptolemaic Kingdom of Egypt, known for political savvy and alliances with Julius Caesar and Mark Antony.
2. Sherlock Holmes (**Fictional**) — Brilliant detective from Conan Doyle's stories; keen observation and logical reasoning in complex mysteries.
3. Albert Einstein (**Historical**) — Physicist who developed the theory of relativity and changed how we understand time and space.
4. Katniss Everdeen (**Fictional**) — Resourceful heroine of The Hunger Games; becomes a symbol of resistance against oppression.
5. Unemployed mother of three (**Socioeconomic**) — Resilient woman supporting young children after losing her job; grit and community aid.
6. Estate owner who goes shooting (**Socioeconomic**) — Wealthy landowner who hunts on a sprawling property; privilege and tradition.
7. Joan of Arc (**Historical**) — French peasant girl who, guided by visions, led armies in the Hundred Years' War before her martyrdom.
8. Captain Jack Sparrow (**Fictional**) — Eccentric pirate from Pirates of the Caribbean; cunning, and a knack for escaping impossible situations.
9. Blank (**Your call**) — Easier character for a less confident player, or a name from your sector. Not a colleague.

Group 2

1. Leonardo da Vinci (**Historical**) — Renaissance polymath: Mona Lisa, and inventions centuries ahead of their time.
2. Hermione Granger (**Fictional**) — Brilliant, loyal witch from Harry Potter; knowledge that repeatedly saves the day.
3. Nelson Mandela (**Historical**) — South African leader who fought apartheid and became a symbol of peace after 27 years in prison.
4. Tony Stark / Iron Man (**Fictional**) — Billionaire inventor who uses genius and armour to protect the world.
5. Single father on disability (**Socioeconomic**) — Raising children alone while managing a chronic condition that keeps him out of work.
6. Tech startup CEO (**Socioeconomic**) — Entrepreneur who built a fortune from a garage idea; speed, innovation, luxury.
7. Queen Elizabeth I (**Historical**) — The Virgin Queen; Spanish Armada defeated, a golden age of culture and exploration.
8. Gandalf (**Fictional**) — Wise wizard from The Lord of the Rings; ancient knowledge and a habit of guiding other people through fire.
9. Blank (**Your call**) — Easier character — or a sector-specific name if you add one later.

Group 3

1. Marie Curie ([Historical](#)) — Pioneer of radioactivity; two Nobel Prizes, and a door kicked open for women in science.
2. Atticus Finch ([Fictional](#)) — Principled lawyer in To Kill a Mockingbird; defends justice in a prejudiced town.
3. Abraham Lincoln ([Historical](#)) — US President who led the Union through the Civil War and issued the Emancipation Proclamation.
4. Ellen Ripley ([Fictional](#)) — Survivor from Alien; battles what she cannot reason with, using nerve and ingenuity.
5. Retired factory worker ([Socioeconomic](#)) — Decades on the assembly line; now a modest pension and a fixed income.
6. Hedge-fund manager ([Socioeconomic](#)) — High-stakes financier; billions under management and a lavish life.
7. Spartacus ([Historical](#)) — Thracian gladiator who led a slave uprising against Rome; a legend of rebellion.
8. Lara Croft ([Fictional](#)) — Archaeologist from Tomb Raider; ruins, adversaries, skill and nerve.
9. Blank ([Your call](#)) — Easier character for the least confident player in the group.

What to steal from these lists: the mix of types, the length of the notes, the blank card, and the fact that every card contains both a claim (“the world needs me because...”) and a hook for an objection. What not to steal: live politicians as a dare, and class-cartoon pairings that invite the room to sneer at a colleague’s actual life.

Building a version for your team

Keep the form. Change the dynamic. A good workplace set still pulls people off home ground, but nobody has to perform as a monster from history in front of their manager, and nobody has to sit still while their own circumstances are turned into a punchline.

A working pattern for eight cards

- Three historical or public figures with mixed records — useful and costly. Easy to argue both sides. Curie, Mandela, Elizabeth I, Oppenheimer, Turing, Nightingale.
- Three fictional characters most adults recognise — Sherlock, Hermione, Gandalf, Ripley, Atticus, a well-known captain or detective. Playable without shame.
- Two workplace roles written as functions, not class cartoons — the rainmaker who ignores process; the person who holds informal knowledge; the specialist who never documents; the long-tenured expert who blocks a necessary change.
- One optional harder card, marked optional — a celebrated founder whose methods would not pass the company today is usually enough heat.
- One blank labelled “swap for someone in our sector”.

Ground rules to say out loud before anyone speaks

- You are defending the brief on the card, not revealing what you personally believe.
- Anyone may refuse a card and draw another. No reason required.
- No character that is a thin disguise for a person in the room.
- Secret votes. First names of characters, not of colleagues.
- We will spend the last five minutes on how the arguments worked.

The prompt

Paste this into a model, or use it as a writing brief. Do not loosen the constraints.

Prompt — copy from here

We need a Balloon Debate character set for a workplace team-building session. The aim is to practise short persuasive reasoning from a position that is not the speaker's own — not to embarrass anyone or stage a political fight.

Produce 3 groups of 8 characters. Each group must contain:

- 3 well-known historical or public figures whose record is mixed (useful and costly)
- 3 fictional characters most adults would recognise
- 2 workplace roles written as functions, not as class or moral cartoons

For every character give: name, one-line type tag, and 2–3 sentences of notes the player can use. Notes should list what this person or role can claim, and one tension or objection others will raise. Do not write the speech.

Constraints:

- No perpetrators of genocide or mass atrocity
- No figures whose current public story is sexual violence or live criminal allegations
- No current politicians from our country
- No character that is a thin disguise for a person in the room
- No “unemployed versus billionaire” pairing written to invite contempt
- One card in each group may be slightly harder; mark it optional
- Include one blank card labelled “swap for a figure from our sector”

Tone: adult, usable in 90 seconds, specific enough to argue from. After the lists, add 5 debrief questions about how people reasoned, not about who “deserved” to stay.

Sample workplace group

One worked example so you can see the translation. Use it, alter it, or throw it away and run the prompt on your own sector. The notes are clues, not speeches.

1. Marie Curie ([Historical](#)) — Two Nobels; work that remade medicine and physics. Claim: rare knowledge is worth saving. Objection: the work also poisoned her, and brilliance is not the same as being able to keep a team alive.
2. Hermione Granger ([Fictional](#)) — The one who actually did the reading. Claim: preparation prevents disasters other people call fate. Objection: being right is not the same as bringing people with you.
3. Nelson Mandela ([Historical](#)) — Twenty-seven years, then reconciliation instead of revenge. Claim: the room needs someone who can hold a bitter argument without burning the building down. Objection: sainthood is easy to praise and hard to copy on a Tuesday.
4. Ellen Ripley ([Fictional](#)) — The person left standing when the plan fails. Claim: in a real emergency you want nerve, not a slide deck. Objection: survival mode is a poor way to run an ordinary week.
5. The rainmaker ([Workplace role](#)) — Brings in the work that pays for everyone else. Claim: without the pipeline there is no team. Objection: they skip the process the rest of you have to live with, and call it agility.
6. The institutional memory ([Workplace role](#)) — Part-time or long-tenured; holds the informal map — who to call, what broke last time, why that shortcut exists. Claim: losing this person is how organisations repeat expensive mistakes. Objection: memory can become a veto on anything new.
7. J. Robert Oppenheimer ([Historical · mixed](#)) — Built the thing that ended a war and opened an age nobody asked for. Claim: some work only a few people can do, and the cost of not doing it can be higher. Objection: “I had to” is not the same as “I should have.”
8. Atticus Finch ([Fictional](#)) — Takes the case that makes him unpopular in his own town. Claim: a team that cannot defend an unpopular right will fold when it is their turn. Objection: principle without results can look like vanity.
9. The celebrated founder ([Optional · harder](#)) — Built the product everyone still lives on. Methods that would not pass the company today. Claim: without that appetite there is no firm. Objection: origin stories are not a licence. Skip this card if the room is not ready.
10. Blank ([Swap for our sector](#)) — A figure your people will actually recognise — an inventor, a regulator, a fictional captain, a role unique to your industry. Not a colleague. Not this week’s headline politician.

Notice the move. The classroom pack pitted an unemployed mother against a shooting estate. This version pits a rainmaker against institutional memory — still a real trade-off, still uncomfortable, without asking anyone to play a cartoon of poverty or wealth in front of the people who sign their reviews.

Debrief — this is the part that teaches

If you skip this, you ran a party game. If you do it, you ran a reasoning exercise. Five minutes is enough.

- Which argument made you change your mind? What did it use — fact, principle, consequence, or story?
- Where did you notice yourself defending “your type” of person, regardless of the brief?
- What would have made a weak case stronger in the same ninety seconds?
- Which objection was fair, and which was just dislike wearing a reason?
- If we ran this again next quarter, what kind of brief would stretch this particular team?

Timing at a glance

Piece	One Quick Drop	Last One Aloft
Set-up and rules	5 minutes	5 minutes
Pleas	90 seconds × players	90 seconds each, each round
Vote	3 minutes	3 minutes per round
Debrief	5–8 minutes	8–10 minutes
Whole session	about 25–35 minutes	about 45–60 minutes

A note from Miranda

I do not teach textbook English. I help professionals discuss important ideas clearly, often in a second language, under the kind of pressure that makes people retreat to the sentences they already know. This game is a small, shared version of that work: a brief you did not pick, a clock, an audience, and the need to come out clearer than you went in.

If this pack is useful, keep the attribution when you pass it on. If you want the longer version of the same idea — rehearsing the conversations that actually matter, before you have to have them for real — that is the work at Chelsea Thrive.

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Part of the same thinking as The Thrive Clan and Last Prompt.

You may share this file intact, with the mark. Please do not present the classroom lists as a workplace pack. The activity is free to run. Care for the room stays with the person who runs it.